was made in the talks. Meanwhile, the extremists on both sides attempted to disrupt the discussions by acts of violence. The USA, however, still kept up the pressure on Israel: in particular, the Americans called on the Israelis to stop building more settlements in the occupied territories or face the risk of losing their financial aid. When elections were held in Israel in 1992, a new, more moderate government was voted into power. This new government promised to work for peace with the Palestinians.

The Oslo Accord 1993

Key question
What was achieved by the 1993 peace agreement?

In 1993, discussions were started up again. This time they were held in secret, in Oslo, in neutral Norway, away from the glare of worldwide publicity. Fourteen sessions of talks were held over eight months. Finally, in September, the PLO leader, Yasser Arafat, and the head of the new Israeli government, Yitzhak Rabin, exchanged letters. Arafat, in his letter, rejected the use of terrorism, called for an end to the *Intifada* and recognised 'the right of Israel to exist in peace and security'. He had never made such clear statements before. Rabin, in his letter, recognised 'the PLO as the representative of the Palestinian people'. In the past, the Israeli government had refused to acknowledge the PLO and had regarded it as just a terrorist organisation.

Key date
Oslo Accords: 1993 and 1995

On 13 September 1993, the two leaders signed an agreement, which became known as the **Oslo Accord**. This paved the way for a step-by-step approach towards self-government for the Palestinians. Then, in front of all the world's cameras at the White House in Washington, Arafat and Rabin shook hands. At last, a major breakthrough had been made in resolving the Palestinian problem. The *Daily Mail* wrote:

Key term
Oslo Accord
The name given to the agreement resulting from peace negotiations held in Oslo.

> Handshake for history. This was the moment no one had dared hope for, organised for a worldwide TV audience by President Clinton on the South Lawn of the White House. At Clinton's right hand was Israeli Prime Minister Yitzhak Rabin, a former general in the Six-Day War when Israel grabbed the occupied territories,



Rabin (left) and Arafat (right) shake hands while US President Clinton looks on.